J. Christian, official in Sunnyvale

BY TRACY SEIPEL
Mercury News Staff Writer

John Christian, the Sunnyvale director of parks and recreation who oversaw some of the city's most significant expansions in public open space, recreation programs, and the development of Sunnyvale's Baylands Park, died Thursday of prostate cancer.

He was 50.



Mr. Christian

Mr. Christian was diagnosed with the disease less than two years ago, and, despite rounds of painful treatment since, managed to continue working part time until a few weeks ago.

"He was the *crème de la crème* when it comes to public sector employees who have a vested interest in the citizens at heart," said Sunnyvale Mayor Robin Parker. "The innovative ways in which he was able to leverage community resources were astounding. We're just extremely saddened to lose such a dedicated public servant."

'An amazing leader'

"It's just a tragic loss," said City Manager Tom Lewcock, who hired Mr. Christian in 1988 from a field of 70 applicants. "He was just an amazing leader, and the legacy he is going to leave will be enjoyed by people in this community for a very long time."

During six years in Sunnyvale, Mr. Christian oversaw a department of 107 full-time employees and an annual budget of $12 million. He is credited with devising progressive parks and recreation programs and services that garnered statewide attention, including the Columbia Neighborhood Center set to open next month.

The $3.5 million center was funded by private business, public school and city money and will provide education, health and other social services for youth, families and residents in the north Sunnyvale neighborhood.

Role in Baylands Park

Mr. Christian also helped plan and develop Sunnyvale Baylands Park, which opened in 1994. Once a vast, raw open space, the park was transformed under Mr. Christian's direction into 72 developed acres, along with 105 acres of undeveloped protected wetlands that are explored by children and adults.

Three months ago, Mr. Christian received the city's Distinguished Citizen of the Year Award, given during the mayor's annual state of the city address.

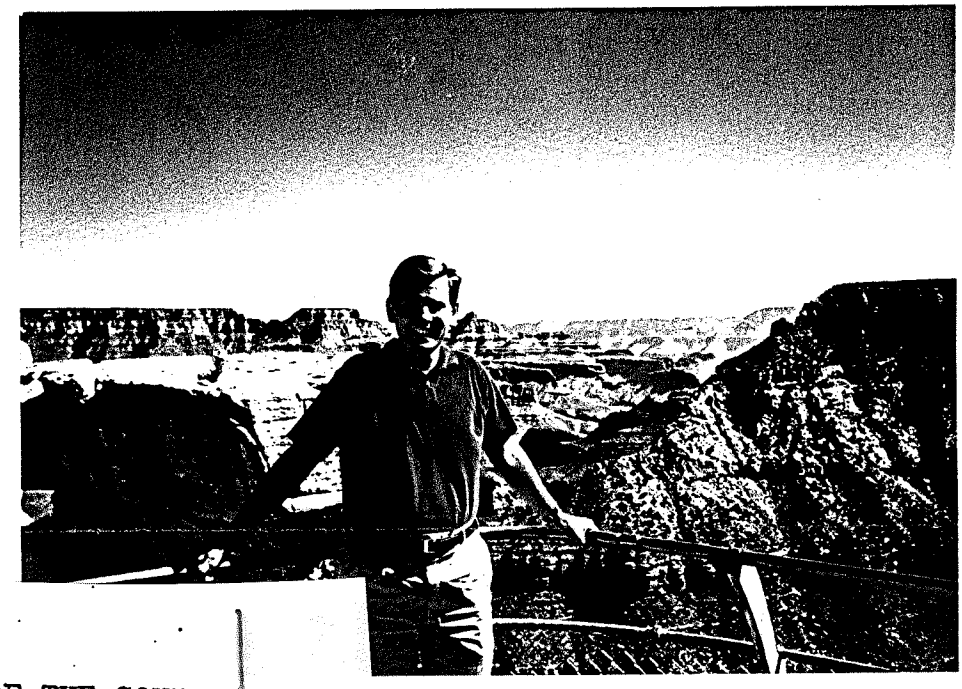
Services are pending.

CHRISTIAN, John W., 50, of Sunnyvale, director of Sunnyvale Parks and Recreation. Service at 2 p.m. Tuesday at St. John's Lutheran Church, Algonquin, Ill. Burial in Algonquin Cemetery, Algonquin, Ill. Memorial service at 7:30 p.m. Aug. 20 at St. Luke Lutheran Church, Sunnyvale. Arrangements by Wyant & Smith Funeral Home, Sunnyvale.

Memorial Donations

John's family identified three organizations for memorial donations in his name. They include;

Sunnyvale Youth Opportunity Fund,
C/O City of Sunnyvale, POB 3707,Sunnyvale 94088
Homestead H. S. Music Boosters
C/O Leslie Roberts, 1386 Bedford Dr,Sunnyvale 94087
St. Luke Lutheran Church,
1025 The Dalles, Sunnyvale Ca 94087-4035



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